

Chapter 71 Part 1

Before returning to the company, Xu Qingzhu went to the coffee shop downstairs to buy a cup of coffee.

When she was about to pay with her phone, she discovered a message from Zhou Yi'an. She paid first.

Just as the staff handed her the coffee, she tapped the screen with one hand to read the message. When she saw the sentence on the screen, her hand trembled and the coffee nearly spilled.

"Careful!" The staff member urgently called out, reaching over the counter to help steady it.

Xu Qingzhu came back to her senses and hastily thanked them.

No matter how much turmoil was churning in her heart, she maintained a calm and composed expression on her face. She closed her phone and entered the company with her coffee.

As a result, she ran into Zhou Yi'an again at the elevator entrance downstairs.

People who had just finished eating lunch outside were crowding back into the company, making the elevator entrance somewhat congested.

Yet Zhou Yi'an seemed to have a special ability to make crowds stay away from her.

She stood alone at the edge, not competing with others for space. With one hand in her pocket and the other playing a mobile game, she casually tapped the screen a few times.

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her across the crowd, then withdrew her gaze.

It was just a simple look, but Zhou Yi'an noticed her too.

However, the two didn't greet each other.

Sally happened to walk over and patted Xu Qingzhu's shoulder. "Blanche, didn't you go to eat with Zhou Yi'an? Why did you come back separately? Did you fight?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "No."

"Alright then." Sally glanced at Zhou Yi'an standing there all alone. "Anyone who could get into a fight with Zhou Yi'an would be quite capable."

Xu Qingzhu: "Hm?"

"Zhou Yi'an is probably the type who would resort to physical action rather than verbal arguments." Sally said.

Xu Qingzhu smiled perfunctorily and didn't continue the topic.

Sally had only been making small talk with her anyway. In the crowded elevator, no one spoke again.

All the way back to her office, Xu Qingzhu placed the coffee on her desk, took out her phone again, then opened her conversation with Zhou Yi'an. That sentence: [A person who has lived in a psychiatric hospital for years—do you think she's doing well?]

Living in a psychiatric hospital for years...

Xu Qingzhu wanted to ask something, but didn't know where to begin.

And she had no motivation to ask.

She sat there thinking—why should she ask?

What use would it be after asking?

What answer did she want to obtain?

Reason forced her back to her original position. After a long while, she replied to Zhou Yi'an: [Truly a case of heaven envying the talented.]

Just like her poor uncle¹.

Geniuses are like shooting stars—they fall at their most brilliant moment.

Zhou Yi'an quickly replied: [?]

As if she hadn't expected her to respond from an outsider's perspective.

And facing this question mark, Xu Qingzhu's reply was: [Let's get to work.]

Zhou Yi'an: [...]

Indeed, very calm.

Calm to the point of being almost cold.

Zhou Yi'an stared at those two replies on the screen, her brows tightly furrowed. She couldn't help but reply: [President Xu must take after her father more.]

Xu Qingzhu: [...What makes you say that?]

Zhou Yi'an: [Those who understand will understand.]

Xu Qingzhu: [Then I don't understand.]

Zhou Yi'an was struggling with whether or not to explain when Xu Qingzhu sent a long message.

[I don't have much time to play guessing games with you. If you want to tell me some groundless rumors, I don't particularly want to hear them. Who I inherited traits from isn't important—what matters is that I've already grown into who I am now. Designer Zhou, it's better for you to interfere less in other people's family affairs. If you have free and ample time, why not think more about our theme proposal for next quarter.]

Zhou Yi'an: [...]

She put down her phone and looked across to Xu Qingzhu's office. The instant their eyes met, Xu Qingzhu closed the venetian blinds² of her office.

Zhou Yi'an suddenly smiled.

Lin Luoxi passed by Zhou Yi'an's workstation and went to Xu Qingzhu's office, placing the documents she had just picked up on her desk. Curiously, she asked: "Why did you suddenly go eat with Zhou Yi'an?"

Xu Qingzhu flipped through the documents while answering: "We discussed something."

"You two didn't fight, did you?" Lin Luoxi asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "No, why?"

Lin Luoxi paused, then shook her head on her own. "As long as you didn't fight. When I just walked past her workstation, I saw her staring at your office and smiling."

Xu Qingzhu: "Huh?"

Lin Luoxi shook her head, trying to drive Zhou Yi'an's smile from her mind, but found it futile.

That person was beautiful, but her smile was rather sinister.

Once you've seen it, it's hard to forget.

Lin Luoxi could only say: "Anyway, be careful. Her smile was... strangely perverted."

Xu Qingzhu: "...Oh."

Footnotes:

¹ Uncle (舅舅, jiùjiu): Refers to Xu Qingzhu's maternal uncle, who was previously mentioned in the story as someone with exceptional talent who died young.

² Venetian blinds (百葉窗, bǎiyèchuāng): Window blinds with horizontal slats that can be adjusted to control light and privacy.

Chapter 71 Part 2

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Xu Qingzhu was indeed a bit distracted at work in the afternoon, but she still forced herself to handle the tasks at hand.

She left the company at three-thirty and drove straight to Dongheng Group's building.

She didn't rush Liang Shi, only sending her a message: [I'm here.]

A few minutes later, Liang Shi came down and spotted her car almost immediately.

Liang Shi was about to get in the driver's seat, but Xu Qingzhu said, "Today, you sit in the passenger seat."

Xu Qingzhu's emotions were somewhat low. You could tell she had deliberately tried to suppress them, but some still leaked through her tone despite her efforts.

After Liang Shi got in the car and fastened her seatbelt, she asked: "Did you encounter problems at work today?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu's voice was cold: "I just interviewed a few people."

"Then did I make you angry?" Liang Shi asked again.

"No." Xu Qingzhu said: "We haven't even talked, so how could I be angry because of you?"

Liang Shi: "..."

A moment later, Xu Qingzhu also realized something was wrong. She added, "What I mean is, it has nothing to do with you."

"So, why are you angry?" Liang Shi asked with a smile.

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

The car remained silent for a long while. Xu Qingzhu suddenly curved her lips into a smile. Her cool voice carried a somewhat alluring quality, her tone lazy yet casual, her voice faint, making it impossible to discern joy or anger. "Zhou Yi'an is Su Yao's student."

Liang Shi was stunned. "What? Zhou Yi'an?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Yes."

Liang Shi was somewhat shocked. "Is it the Zhou Yi'an I know?"

She asked twice in succession, appearing somewhat foolish, but Xu Qingzhu couldn't bring herself to smile. "It's her. And the girl who went with me to Yunfeng Mountain last time is Su Yao's niece, also the heiress of Haiwei Jewelry."

Xu Qingzhu told Liang Shi about all the external shocks she had received throughout the day.

Liang Shi was also dazed for a few seconds, then smiled bitterly: "Should we say it's fate?"

"Indeed, quite fateful." Xu Qingzhu also smiled.

This world seems so large, but actually it's like a spider web, connecting everyone together.

But thinking about it again, it seemed reasonable.

These people all belonged to the same social circle, so their perspectives and circumstances would naturally attract similar people.

"And then?" Liang Shi asked: "Did you go find out anything?"

"We talked a bit." Xu Qingzhu said: "Zhou Yi'an seems to know quite a lot about these matters. She wanted to tell me, but I didn't ask."

Liang Shi: "..."

Xu Qingzhu's rationality once again refreshed her understanding.

"It's probably better that you didn't ask." Liang Shi consoled her: "Anyway, they're not particularly important people."

Xu Qingzhu didn't respond, but after a while, Xu Qingzhu asked: "What kind of person would stay in a psychiatric hospital all the time?"

"Patients and doctors." Liang Shi answered: "And nurses."

After answering, Liang Shi suddenly understood. "You're talking about Su Yao?"

"Yes." Xu Qingzhu's tone was like discussing a stranger, if you could ignore the slight tremor in her trailing voice. "Zhou Yi'an said she's been living in a psychiatric hospital for years."

"Then does she have... mental problems?" Liang Shi asked carefully.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "Perhaps."

Then she didn't continue the topic.

Liang Shi sat there alone, her mind running through all sorts of chaotic thoughts.

If the Haiwei Jewelry heiress is Su Meiqi, and Su Yao is Su Meiqi's aunt, then Su Yao must be the younger sister of Haiwei Jewelry's CEO?

So the reason nothing about Su Yao was exposed back then was because she had a fairly powerful wealthy family.

And her family protected her extremely well.

After Sheng Qinglin's death, Su Yao disappeared for a while—she was also hidden by her family.

Living in a psychiatric hospital for years...

Did she have a mental breakdown after being traumatized? Does she still remember she has a daughter?

Liang Shi felt the truth was right before her eyes, but she didn't really want to investigate.

She was afraid of upsetting Xu Qingzhu.

But as an outsider, even she couldn't help wanting to understand the whole story. After all, Su Yao and Sheng Qinglin loved each other so much—it was impossible for them not to raise the fruit of their love.

With their financial means, there was no way Xu Qingzhu would end up in the Sheng family's hands.

But... why exactly?

How much strength did Xu Qingzhu have to use to suppress her curiosity about her own origins?

Thinking this, Liang Shi suddenly let out a heavy sigh, her face full of worry.

This appearance actually made Xu Qingzhu laugh.

Turning at an intersection, Xu Qingzhu spoke: "Teacher Liang, think more about your own matters. Don't worry about me."

Liang Shi: "..."

"I'll think about it some more." Xu Qingzhu said: "Who knows, maybe I'll come to terms with it one day."

Footnotes:

None needed for this section.

Chapter 71 Part 3

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The road to Ci'ai Nursing Home¹ wasn't too boring, though the atmosphere was somewhat heavy.

Although Xu Qingzhu spoke lightly about how she might come to terms with it one day, Liang Shi still heard the fragility beneath her feigned composure.

She must be afraid.

But unwilling to show others her fear.

Liang Shi didn't express any more opinions on the matter, instead saying to her: "Teacher Xu, no matter what decision you make, I'll support you."

After a pause, she added: "Just like how you support me."

"I haven't really supported you either." Xu Qingzhu said calmly: "It's just pure curiosity."

Xu Qingzhu attributed everything she had done to curiosity rather than helping Liang Shi, trying to lighten Liang Shi's psychological burden.

Liang Shi accepted this sentiment, but secretly made a resolution.

—To uncover the truth.

If one day Xu Qingzhu wanted to know the truth buried beneath the surface of her current life, then she would provide that truth.

If Xu Qingzhu didn't want to know, then she would bury that truth completely.

From the city center to Ci'ai Nursing Home, they had to travel through a long stretch of mountain road. During this time, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu switched positions.

One person driving for too long could lead to drowsy driving. After driving for nearly an hour, they finally arrived at Ci'ai Nursing Home.

Ci'ai Nursing Home backed onto a large mountain. Now in late autumn, the mountain had turned a withered yellow, and the road at the nursing home's entrance was covered with fallen leaves.

In summer, this place should be quite comfortable.

Liang Shi parked the car by the roadside. After Xu Qingzhu got out, they headed toward the entrance together.

The gatekeepers were two young security guards. One sat in the security room playing games, while the other sat at the entrance with a red classroom desk in front of him, on which sat a visitor registration book.

The one sitting at the entrance had his phone propped up, watching a TV drama.

It happened to be Zhao Ying's drama. He watched with a foolish grin.

Liang Shi walked over and asked: "Hello, I'd like to ask..."

Before she could finish, the security guard interrupted, "Who are you here to see? Register first."

Liang Shi said: "I'm looking for the director. Is he here?"

"Looking for the director?" The security guard paused his TV drama. "Who are you? What do you need the director for?"

Liang Shi said: "I have some things I'd like to ask about."

The security guard frowned: "What things? Our director is very busy."

"It's fine." Xu Qingzhu said: "We'll just call him ourselves."

The security guard looked at the two of them with an expression of utter speechlessness.

Xu Qingzhu had gotten the director's phone number from Lin Luoxi and called him. He quickly came out from his office.

Liang Shi once again experienced what it meant to have connections that make things easier.

The reason Xu Qingzhu gave the director for her visit was that she wanted to see the current management of Hazhou City's nursing homes and their material needs.

If necessary, she could provide funding.

This nursing home didn't really need funding, but Xu Qingzhu had learned from Lin Luoxi that the director currently had the idea of rebuilding an orphanage, so he would need money.

He would also need attention from various sectors of society, so the director would make friends widely.

The director wasn't tall, was lean, wore black-framed glasses, dressed in casual sportswear, and had new running shoes on his feet. When he came to meet them, he even jogged a few steps.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu each introduced themselves, and also learned that this director's surname was Gu, given name Zhaoyuan.

All the information matched what Xu Qingzhu had learned from Lin Luoxi beforehand.

Gu Zhaoyuan's father had founded Angel Orphanage back then, taking in abandoned infants and disabled children from Hazhou City. Some children with better prospects were adopted by wealthy and powerful families, all through anonymous adoption.

Later, Gu Zhaoyuan's father fell seriously ill and converted Angel Orphanage into Ci'ai Nursing Home. At once, it transformed from a money-losing orphanage into a profitable nursing home. Moreover, many of those children who had grown up in Angel Orphanage became employees of Ci'ai Nursing Home.

Most of these people were disabled individuals who couldn't find work in society.

Because they hadn't accepted new children for many years, the youngest of the last batch of children who entered Angel Orphanage was already 15 years old this year.

And after the nursing home became profitable, Gu Zhaoyuan would send school-age children to study. The children would work at the nursing home in their spare time, and their pocket money came from their wages.

In a sense, the orphanage and nursing home had achieved a balance.

With this model already in place, Gu Zhaoyuan's mind became active again, wanting to reestablish an orphanage. This was because he himself was an abandoned infant who had been adopted by the previous director and became his adopted son, inheriting this nursing home.

In fact, the old Director Gu had never married or had children. He had devoted all his energy in the first half of his life to building the orphanage, and Gu Zhaoyuan, influenced by him, planned to make this work his lifelong faith.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu followed him as they toured the nursing home, learning about the nursing home's history and current development from him.

Footnotes:

¹ Ci'ai Nursing Home (慈愛養老院, Cí'ài Yǎnglǎoyuàn): "Ci'ai" literally means "loving kindness/compassionate love." The name reflects the caring nature of the facility.

Chapter 71 Part 4

The nursing home's fees were at the average level for Hazhou City, but because most of the staff here were those once-abandoned children, they took care of the residents very attentively and could get along well with the elderly.

Currently, there were over 120 people living in the nursing home. They had established a unified cafeteria, bathhouse, activity center, and dormitories, and even offered classes for the elderly.

Because Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu were more interested in Angel Orphanage, and Gu Zhaoyuan also wanted them to understand more about establishing the orphanage, he talked at length about many amusing incidents from the orphanage days.

A group of children abandoned by their parents had formed new families. They treated each other as brothers and sisters, living together every day. Occasionally they would envy the children who were adopted, but many children who were adopted would run back because they missed the orphanage.

Gu Zhaoyuan had always felt this work was meaningful and worth doing.

When he expressed this view, Liang Shi suddenly asked: "Then why did your father suddenly stop doing it?"

Gu Zhaoyuan's smile suddenly froze on his face, then turned into a bitter smile. He shook his head helplessly and said: "Can I say that I don't know either?"

Liang Shi was puzzled: "When your father wanted to convert it into a nursing home, you should have already been helping him. How could you..."

"My father kept some things from us when he did them." Gu Zhaoyuan explained earnestly: "Many of the children who left Angel Orphanage, especially those adopted by wealthy families—their records would be erased from the orphanage. When my father handled this part, he never let us get involved because we couldn't really help. Moreover..."

He paused, "My father suddenly became ill after being traumatized."

"May I politely ask what year your father fell ill?" Liang Shi asked.

Gu Zhaoyuan suddenly became guarded. "Why are you asking these things?"

Liang Shi hadn't intended to hide anything. She vaguely revealed her purpose for coming: "We have a friend who came out of Angel Orphanage and now wants to look into this friend's past."

"Who?" Gu Zhaoyuan asked.

Liang Shi shook her head: "I'm sorry, I can't say, but we suspect your father's illness might be related to her."

Xu Qingzhu had asked Lin Luoxi, so she knew that Angel Orphanage was converted into Ci'ai Nursing Home ten years ago.

That was the third year after Qi Jiao's jumping incident.

Liang Shi was only speculating. She said this to Gu Zhaoyuan just to find a more reasonable excuse.

Sure enough, as soon as she said this, Gu Zhaoyuan immediately responded: "My father's illness? I also don't know what traumatized him to become like this now. You actually know?"

"Just speculation." Liang Shi said: "Many things happened to our friend, and the timing is very close to when your father fell seriously ill."

She spoke ambiguously, yet it made Gu Zhaoyuan fall into contemplation.

Liang Shi sighed softly. "Could you take us to meet your father?"

Gu Zhaoyuan slowly shook his head. "I'm sorry, my father's consciousness isn't very clear now. He often speaks nonsense. It's better not to meet him."

"Then do you still have the group photos from the orphanage?" Liang Shi said: "I heard from my friend that you took group photos every year with all the children in them."

"Yes, we do." Gu Zhaoyuan answered.

This wasn't a difficult request to fulfill, so Gu Zhaoyuan led them to his office.

His office was very simple—just a desk, two chairs, and a bookshelf with various types of books on it.

When they entered, there was a little boy wiping the windows.

The boy's foot was somewhat lame, but he worked very earnestly.

Gu Zhaoyuan told him to return to the dormitory to rest, and the boy limped out.

Liang Shi kept watching his foot, her heart quietly filling with sympathy. At the same time, she gained a deeper understanding of what Director Gu was doing. The old Director Gu, who had persisted in charitable work all this time, was truly admirable.

She suddenly wanted to do something for these causes too.

She was so lost in thought that she didn't hear Gu Zhaoyuan calling her. It was only when Xu Qingzhu touched her arm that she came back to her senses and said softly: "I'm sorry."

"It's fine." Gu Zhaoyuan handed her the photo album.

This photo album wasn't like ordinary albums. Although each photo had a year and date on it, and the background was always Angel Orphanage, every single photo showed signs of being cut.

Some had many people cut out, some fewer—it was purely a matter of luck.

Liang Shi asked: "Were all the cut-out ones adopted by wealthy families?"

"Not necessarily." Gu Zhaoyuan said: "Some adopting families had requirements, and we would meet their requests."

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu looked through the album together, examining each photo carefully, but they didn't find anyone resembling Qi Jiao.

If there was one, it had probably been cut out.

Gu Zhaoyuan said his father fell seriously ill the year before Angel Orphanage was changed to Ci'ai Nursing Home.

After the illness, once he regained some consciousness, he established Ci'ai Nursing Home.

Not long after that, his mental state became somewhat abnormal.

Liang Shi frowned. It seemed they hadn't found many clues here either.

The previous director had done everything seamlessly. Unless they could ask him directly, but now Gu Zhaoyuan wouldn't give them the opportunity to meet the old director.

Having found no clues, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu didn't propose leaving. Instead, they wandered around the nursing home.

The activity center in the back was very lively. A group of elderly people gathered together—some playing poker, some playing badminton, and others sitting together chatting while knitting sweaters.

There were all kinds of people. The staff members responsible for looking after them were all children who had once been at Angel Orphanage.

Facing this work of interacting with the elderly, they didn't feel annoyed at all. Rather, their faces showed genuinely satisfied smiles. Some elderly people would pull them over and chat with them at length.

The missing familial affection seemed to be fulfilled in an instant.

It was as if they were the real family.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu even had dinner at the nursing home cafeteria. They followed behind Gu Zhaoyuan, and along the way, many people greeted him.

It was clear that Gu Zhaoyuan was very popular here.

Footnotes:

None needed for this section.

Chapter 71 Part 5

The cafeteria food was similar to school cafeterias, but tasted a bit better. There were three dishes and a soup, and you could choose whether you wanted rice, noodles, or steamed buns and baozi¹.

Liang Shi ate quickly. After finishing, she observed everyone sitting there. Those young-looking children acted very steadily, having gone through each procedure many times, and their faces showed a maturity beyond their years.

Liang Shi looked down at her account balance again—still over 200,000, nearly 300,000.

After the meal, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu prepared to leave. Gu Zhaoyuan saw them to the entrance.

Gu Zhaoyuan seemed apologetic. "I'm sorry I couldn't provide you with help."

"It's fine." Liang Shi said: "I saw many other things, and I'm very interested in your future project. If you want to establish a new orphanage, I'd be happy to help."

Gu Zhaoyuan was stunned. "Huh?"

Actually, from the moment these two said they wanted to consult about matters, he hadn't held any hope for them.

Every year, quite a few people came here to investigate things. They basically all came under the pretext of wanting to donate money or goods, but in the end, after looking around and not finding the results they wanted, they would leave and never again mention helping this place.

But Liang Shi said very sincerely: "Director Gu, give me your account number. I don't have much money on hand right now, but I can buy some clothes and things for the children here."

Gu Zhaoyuan was truly bewildered. "For the children?"

"Yes." Liang Shi said: "There are still many school-age students here, right? Buy them some clothes and such. Also, if any child is short on tuition and you're tight on funds, you can call me. I'll help them with the tuition fees. They must study hard."

After saying this, she smiled gently. "I won't take up any more of your time. Please give me your account number."

Gu Zhaoyuan took out his phone and entered a string of numbers. "This is our special donation account. When you donate, enter your name and email, as well as the purpose of the funds. After we implement it, we'll send you photos and an expense list to ensure your money was used on the people you intended it for."

This was essentially telling Liang Shi that her money wouldn't be embezzled by others, but would truly go to charity.

Liang Shi efficiently transferred 100,000 to him. "Winter is coming soon. Buy the children new winter coats."

After the transfer, Liang Shi added: "I noticed there's only a library for the elderly here, and not many books. Many children don't have books to read. If I have time this week, I'll send over a batch of books. Will you have time?"

"Yes." Gu Zhaoyuan was in a continued state of bewilderment and immediately said: "I'm here every day."

"Good." Liang Shi said: "I hope you can get the orphanage running again."

Gu Zhaoyuan seemed as energized as if he'd been injected with adrenaline² and smiled: "Definitely!"

After saying this, they bid farewell to Gu Zhaoyuan. But Gu Zhaoyuan suddenly called out to them: "Whose records are you looking for? Perhaps I can be of help."

Liang Shi paused, then shook her head. "This is my friend's privacy. I can't say. We came here just to try our luck."

"Then when you come next time, I'll take you to see my father." Gu Zhaoyuan said: "He might know something."

Liang Shi nodded and smiled. "Alright."

Standing to the side, Xu Qingzhu looked at Liang Shi, thinking that Liang Shi had quite a few methods for winning people's hearts—she was quite capable.

At first, Gu Zhaoyuan had clearly been perfunctory with them, always speaking in official platitudes.

But after Liang Shi did this, Gu Zhaoyuan looked at her with new eyes and was even willing to help arrange a meeting with the previous director.

Xu Qingzhu felt she was getting to know Liang Shi anew.

But Liang Shi hadn't thought that much. As they were about to leave, Liang Shi also left Gu Zhaoyuan her phone number.

She handed him a sticky note rather than choosing to exchange numbers with Gu Zhaoyuan.

She had also written her name on the sticky note.

After handing it over, Gu Zhaoyuan paused, then said: "Your wife has my contact information. If you want to come over, you can contact me in advance."

Liang Shi nodded: "Alright."

At the same time, Gu Zhaoyuan placed that sticky note in his wallet.

His wallet was leather, with worn edges—it looked like it had some age to it. Liang Shi only glanced at it casually, but after looking away, she was suddenly startled and immediately said: "Director Gu, is that photo in your wallet of you and your father?"

Gu Zhaoyuan nodded: "Mm, and my younger sister."

"Your younger sister?" Liang Shi frowned: "May I take a look?"

Gu Zhaoyuan was somewhat hesitant, but Liang Shi said: "I mean no harm. I just feel your sister looks very familiar, like I've seen her somewhere."

"She's already passed away." Gu Zhaoyuan smiled bitterly, but still carefully took out the photo tucked in the wallet compartment, saying with a trace of nostalgia: "You probably saw someone who looks a bit like her."

Liang Shi took the photo. Xu Qingzhu also leaned over to look, and was indeed startled at first glance.

The girl in this photo had facial features that were sixty percent similar to the middle school-aged Qi Jiao they had seen from Zhao Xuning.

You just needed to lift all her features upward a bit.

This type of facial structure was easy to adjust.

Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi looked at each other, both seeing shock in each other's eyes.

Liang Shi asked: "What was your sister's name?"

"Gu Xingyue³." Gu Zhaoyuan said: "She had a very withdrawn personality. She couldn't speak until she was seven. We all thought she was mute."

"May I politely ask when she passed away?" Liang Shi asked.

Gu Zhaoyuan smiled bitterly. "Not long after this photo was taken, she passed away. My father took her on a trip and they had a car accident."

"More specifically?" Liang Shi asked again.

"End of 2010⁴." Gu Zhaoyuan said: "She was 13 that year."

Liang Shi returned the photo to Gu Zhaoyuan. "I'm sorry, that was rude of me."

"It's fine." Gu Zhaoyuan said: "Thinking about it now, my father must have also been affected by my sister's death. You can only say it was from accumulated stress and fatigue."

Liang Shi didn't know how to comfort him, but Gu Zhaoyuan didn't need comforting either. He just said to them: "It's quite far to drive back to the city from here. You should leave soon. Be careful on the road."

Liang Shi nodded. "Alright."

Footnotes:

¹ Baozi (包子, bāozi): Chinese steamed buns typically filled with meat or vegetables, a common staple food in China.

² Adrenaline (literally "chicken blood" 雞血, jīxuè): A Chinese colloquial expression meaning to be energized or pumped up, similar to "pumped full of adrenaline" in English.

³ Gu Xingyue (古星月, Gǔ Xīngyuè): The name literally means "Ancient Star-Moon." "Xing" (星) means star and "Yue" (月) means moon. This name was given because she was found under the stars and moon, as explained in the text.

⁴ 2010: This is a crucial timeline detail. Qi Jiao jumped in summer 2010, and Gu Xingyue died in a "car accident" at the end of 2010—suggesting a connection between these two events.

Chapter 71 Part 6

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After bidding farewell to Gu Zhaoyuan, the car drove away from Ci'ai Nursing Home. For a while, neither of them spoke.

After returning home, Liang Shi drank some water, then said: "Let's sort out the timeline."

"I've already sorted it out." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "?"

While she was driving, Xu Qingzhu had already sorted out the timeline. Now she just needed to write it down following her phone.

"Qi Jiao jumped in the summer of 2010, and Gu Zhaoyuan's younger sister Gu Xingyue died in a car accident at the end of 2010. Moreover, there were no photos of Gu Xingyue in the album Gu Zhaoyuan gave us. Only in the group photo that Gu Zhaoyuan kept could we see Gu Xingyue's face." Xu Qingzhu analyzed methodically. "In 2012, the old Director Gu fell seriously ill, then his mental state became somewhat abnormal. He converted the orphanage into a nursing home, and even said things like he had harmed the children."

"So..." Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu said in unison: "Gu Xingyue is the current Qi Jiao."

They hadn't expected things to progress so smoothly. The truth was right before their eyes.

"But why would Gu Xingyue stay by Mrs. Qi's side all the time? Logically speaking, given Director Gu's personality, if he discovered Gu Xingyue wasn't comfortable staying with Mrs. Qi, he would have taken her away, right?" Liang Shi wondered. "And why did it take a year before he discovered there was a problem?"

"That's something we'd have to ask Director Gu." Xu Qingzhu said: "But what I can't understand is, clearly Gu Xingyue was doing well with Director Gu. Why would Director Gu be willing to hand her over to Mrs. Qi?"

Liang Shi: "...For money?"

"That's possible. But I asked Luoxi, and she said Angel Orphanage wasn't too short on money back then because many wealthy people would donate to it." Xu Qingzhu said: "But we can't rule out that reason either."

It was truly a mystery.

Probably only those involved would know.

But discovering this was already quite good.

At least they didn't have to search for clues like headless flies anymore.

But knowing this truth made both Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu's hearts feel somewhat heavy. The original Qi Jiao had already passed away. What remained now was someone else's adopted daughter.

Because of this adopted daughter, a person who had been doing charity work for years was driven insane.

And in this world, there were still people who remembered her.

When Gu Zhaoyuan mentioned Gu Xingyue, his eyes still brimmed with tears.

Liang Shi's heart felt as if it was being pressed down by a large stone. The Qi Jiao she had seen in her dream was sensible, kind, and lovely, but her life had permanently stopped in her teenage years.

To help her ease her sad emotions, Xu Qingzhu teased: "Teacher Liang is quite good at getting things done. You actually thought to use donating money to soften Gu Zhaoyuan's heart."

"No." Liang Shi said in a low voice: "I genuinely want to do something for those children."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Saying this made it seem like she was being narrow-minded.

However, when Xu Qingzhu saw those scenes, she didn't feel as sentimental as Liang Shi did.

At that time, when she saw Liang Shi observing those children, her eyes were red.

She guessed it was probably the empathy of an actor.

"You seem to place particular emphasis on education?" Xu Qingzhu said: "I have many books at home that I've finished reading. We can take them to those children."

"Great." Liang Shi perked up again. "Tomorrow after work, I'll go to a bookstore and buy some reference books. When I have time, I'll go deliver them."

"Sure." Xu Qingzhu said: "You can call me to come along."

"Okay."

The two discussed for a while, then both collapsed on the sofa.

Each lost in their own thoughts.

Footnotes:

None needed for this section.

Chapter 71 Part 7

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[Ding dong! Congratulations to the host for completing Side Quest 2! This time you finally didn't complete the task at the last second—worth encouraging! (To be honest, I really thought the host had late-stage procrastination.) This task reward is 50,000 RMB, which will be transferred to the host's account within ten minutes. Please check for it!]

[Please note, there are currently two tasks remaining uncompleted in the host's task list. Please complete them as soon as possible!]

[Please note again, the host's luck value has accumulated to 87, with misfortune value at 0. If the host has not completed the hidden task and Side Quest 1 after the luck value reaches 90, the system will delay issuing new tasks. At the same time, luck value accumulation will be paused until the host completes the hidden task and Side Quest 1.]

[PS: The hidden task and Side Quest 1 can be abandoned at any time within 24 hours before the deadline. After abandoning, the system will automatically calculate the luck value for the host, and will no longer issue high-reward tasks. Please make your own decision, host.]

[Secretly complaining—Little System thinks the host could never possibly give up these high-reward tasks. After all, the host is a money-grubber! But you also need to complete the tasks quickly. According to Little System's detection, the host's luck value has been accumulating very quickly recently! Getting your own body back is just around the corner.]

[Thinking about how the host will leave the Resentment Management Bureau and Little System will no longer be able to communicate with the host makes Little System feel sad. Wuwuwu! But Little System will go find the next host.]

The system still maintained its original talkative nature, chattering a lot and adding theatrical personality, putting on a one-person show.

Liang Shi lay in bed receiving all these words, then checked her account—the money had indeed arrived.

Now she had money to buy books for those children.

Today she had originally wanted to donate 200,000, but considering she would need to rent and move later, as well as keep some emergency living funds, she was a bit stingy.

The money the system gave now was like sending coal in snowy weather¹.

At the same time, Liang Shi was considering whether to abandon that hidden task. After all, finding Xu Qingzhu's biological parents was quite difficult now.

But after checking the task panel later, she discovered that not completing this task had no penalty, and she didn't need to abandon it early either.

She might as well keep this task.

However, the task was: Find Xu Qingzhu's biological parents.

Had she found them now?

Then why hadn't she been notified that the task was complete?

Mutual recognition was an extra reward—it wasn't mandatory.

As Liang Shi was thinking, the eerie electronic voice belonging to the system sounded in her mind: [There's still a PS! It must be based on Xu Qingzhu's acknowledgment, and there must be a complete chain of evidence.]

Liang Shi: "..."

She asked: "Doesn't it count now? What constitutes a complete chain of evidence?"

System: [Something scientifically verified, like DNA.]

"I thought speculation would count." Liang Shi said: "You guys are as tricky as ever."

System: [...]

A few seconds later, the system said indignantly: [You don't even have a complete chain of evidence now! You're only speculating!! Moreover, the speculation might not even be correct. This matter is very complicated! You need to investigate the entire thing to count.]

Liang Shi: "?"

"Complicated?" Liang Shi struck while the iron was hot: "How complicated? Are the two families sworn enemies?"

The system regained its composure: [Do your own tasks yourself. Don't expect me to help, thank you!]

Liang Shi: "..."

Useless thing.

However, Liang Shi had obtained another piece of information from it, which also confirmed her thoughts from the side.

There must be hidden circumstances behind why Xu Qingzhu wasn't taken away by Su Yao back then.

Countless scenes from wealthy family idol dramas had flashed through her mind, then all died down.

Even if Xu Qingzhu and Su Yao recognized each other now, it would be quite awkward.

There was also a younger sister who might or might not be from the same parents.

Sheng Qinglin had been dead for so many years. That child probably wasn't Sheng Qinglin's, right?

Wouldn't that mean Su Yao had gotten married?

But Qi Jiao—no, perhaps she should now be called Gu Xingyue—had once said that Sheng Yu was a child from a single-parent family with only a mother.

It was truly hard to fathom.

However, Zhou Yi'an should know something, but Liang Shi couldn't possibly go ask Zhou Yi'an.

Xu Qingzhu hadn't gone to hear the truth from her, so she wouldn't go listen either.

This was respect for Xu Qingzhu.

And she was investigating the truth only to give Xu Qingzhu one more choice.

Xu Qingzhu could choose to continue her current life, but if one day she changed her mind, Liang Shi would present the truth to her.

Footnotes:

¹ Sending coal in snowy weather (雪中送炭, xuězhōng sòngtàn): A Chinese idiom meaning to provide help when it's most needed, similar to "a friend in need is a friend indeed" in English.

Chapter 71 Part 8

//

At the same moment, at Ci'ai Orphanage.

Gu Zhaoyuan lay in bed tossing and turning, unable to sleep. Things he had deliberately tried to forget were brought up again. He turned on the light in his room and took out a photo album from the drawer.

Actually, calling it a photo album—it was just three photos.

One was a solo photo of Gu Xingyue standing under a tree. In the photo, she smiled serenely. Another was a photo of him and Gu Xingyue together. At sunset, the two sat side by side on the steps eating bread. That year, Gu Xingyue had just lost her baby teeth¹. The third photo showed their father standing in the middle, holding his hand with one hand and Gu Xingyue's with the other.

His younger sister was someone Father and he had found when coming down from the mountain. At that time, she was wrapped in a cloth bundle and didn't cry. She looked sickly.

It was nighttime then. The stars were bright, and the North Star shone brilliantly in the distant sky.

So they named her Xingyue—Star-Moon.

Xingyue's health wasn't good. She coughed constantly. Father found many doctors for her. They all said she wouldn't live past this year, but later Xingyue miraculously lived year after year.

When Gu Zhaoyuan was young, he often took his sister up the mountain to play. His sister was beautiful but never spoke.

Sometimes the mischievous children in the orphanage would call her a mute.

In the entire orphanage, only he and Xingyue had the surname Gu. Most of the other children had their own names, and those who didn't were given other names by Father.

Gu Zhaoyuan had once asked why, among so many children, only he and his sister called him Father?

Everyone else called him Director.

Father said: "Affinity."

It was such a simple reason that made them into a family.

Actually, all the children in the orphanage younger than him were his younger brothers and sisters, but only Gu Xingyue was different.

He watched Gu Xingyue grow up. Later, his sister kept getting sick—coughing, catching colds, running fevers. Her body was weak. The doctor said she needed a good environment to recuperate.

So Father took her traveling outside, but unexpectedly, they had a car accident.

He hadn't even seen his sister one last time.

Gu Zhaoyuan now thought back to those days spent with his sister—they seemed like another lifetime.

His fingertips caressed the photo as he smiled bitterly and shed a tear.

Then he put down the photo and got up to go to his father's room.

His father's room kept a dim yellow light on year-round. Father had already fallen asleep.

He sat at the edge of his father's bed, staring blankly for a while.

In the middle of the night, his father suddenly furrowed his brows tightly and began talking in his sleep.

"Xingyue..." Father murmured, "Xingyue..."

Gu Zhaoyuan smiled bitterly. "You're thinking of Xingyue too."

Father suddenly opened his eyes and began to cry like a child.

Gu Zhaoyuan immediately patted his back, soothing him in a low voice: "It's okay, it's okay..."

Father cried while asking: "Zhaoyuan, have you seen Xingyue? Did she go up the mountain? I dreamed she went up the mountain and never came back."

"She didn't go up the mountain." Gu Zhaoyuan was already used to such situations. "She's sleeping in her room."

"But I dreamed a bad woman took her away." Father's old tears flowed freely. "My Xingyue, she's suffering."

Gu Zhaoyuan soothed him in a low voice: "No, Xingyue is asleep."

"Then I need to go see her." Father said, getting up. Like a child, he wiped his tears and headed straight out. Gu Zhaoyuan immediately pulled him back. "Father, Xingyue has grown up. She's a young lady now. You can't go into her room."

"But I dreamed someone was beating her." Father raised his hand, his eyes terribly red. He raised his arm high, then brought it down heavily. "Just like this. My Xingyue, she was being beaten and didn't even dare to cry..."

Gu Zhaoyuan was shocked at these words. "Who was beating her?"

Father became crazy and confused again, repeating just those few sentences over and over. The one he recited most was: "My Xingyue..."

Gu Zhaoyuan sighed helplessly and with heartache.

Footnotes:

¹ Lost her baby teeth (換牙, huànyá): Refers to the natural process during childhood when baby teeth fall out and are replaced by permanent teeth, typically occurring between ages 6-12.

Chapter 71 Part 9

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As dusk fell, the streetlights along the road lit up one after another.

Zhou Yi'an drove to the Su family villa, carrying a cake in her hand.

Sheng Yu was the first to see her. She jumped high, raising her hand and shouting: "Sister An!"

Zhou Yi'an curved her lips into a smile. She pocketed her car keys, handed the cake to a servant, then scooped up Sheng Yu in one motion. Then her arm sank down, and she frowned at Sheng Yu. "Have you gained weight again?"

Sheng Yu's mouth drooped. "No!"

"Kids need to grow." Zhou Yi'an said: "I'm not scolding you."

"But after you say I've gotten heavier, you won't hold me anymore." Sheng Yu hugged her neck and acted spoiled. "Hold me more."

"Hold, hold, hold—" Zhou Yi'an said helplessly, "But don't pull my hair, okay?"

Sheng Yu's eyes rolled around. "Oops, you found out."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"Obviously." Zhou Yi'an slapped her on the bottom. "You're pulling so hard it hurts."

"Wuwuwu~" Sheng Yu looked aggrieved. "Sister! Sister An hit me."

Su Meiqi happened to come downstairs, wearing her caterpillar-like onesie pajamas with the hood on. Hearing this, she glanced at the fake-crying Sheng Yu. "Why are you calling me? I can't beat her anyway."

Sheng Yu: "..."

Zhou Yi'an sat down holding Sheng Yu, then politely greeted Mr. and Mrs. Su Zhe, and asked about Su Yao's condition.

Before Su Zhe could speak, Su Yao walked out of her room. Her complexion was still somewhat pale, but much better compared to previous years.

She wasn't like in previous years when, at this time, she would be bedridden with constant nightmares.

"Teacher Su." Zhou Yi'an greeted her. Su Yao nodded. "You're here."

After that, the Su family had dinner. Sheng Yu clung to Zhou Yi'an and sat on her lap. Su Meiqi was on the other side.

Zhou Yi'an hadn't even started eating herself when she began feeding Sheng Yu first.

Su Meiqi couldn't help but say: "Sheng Yu, how old are you? Can't you feed yourself?"

Sheng Yu pouted. "I want Sister An to feed me."

Zhou Yi'an fed her a spoonful of rice: "You're really being clingy right now."

Su Meiqi looked at her. "Your patience has really grown."

Zhou Yi'an: "Has it?"

Su Meiqi immediately lowered her head. "You continue."

When Su Yao saw Sheng Yu constantly bothering Zhou Yi'an, she called Sheng Yu's name in a cold voice and told her to eat by herself. Only then did Zhou Yi'an gain her freedom.

While eating, Su Meiqi still wore her hood. The brim was loose and floppy. When she lowered her head, the hood was about to fall into her plate.

Su Zhe glanced at her and was about to scold her when Zhou Yi'an directly reached out and removed her hood, revealing Su Meiqi's frizzy curly hair.

Everyone: "?"

Su Meiqi: "!"

"What are you doing?!" Su Meiqi frantically put her hood back on. "Zhou Yi'an, don't just grab things, okay?"

Zhou Yi'an was also surprised. "What did you do today?"

Su Meiqi: "...Hanging out with friends."

"What kind of questionable friends are you hanging out with now?" Su Zhe said coldly: "I tell you to come to the company and you don't. All you do is run around outside all day, mixing with those bad friends of yours, wearing all sorts of strange outfits and running around everywhere!"

"I didn't." Su Meiqi argued: "I just went to a comic convention¹."

"Anyway, stop doing all that stuff in the future. Come to my company next week." Su Zhe said.

"I'm not going." Su Meiqi said: "I've already found a job and will start work soon. If you don't like seeing me, I'll just move out."

Su Zhe said sternly: "Stop using this to threaten me. What kind of person you are, do you think I don't know? You're definitely lying to me again about finding work, then running off to mess around with those bad friends."

"What do you mean 'bad friends'?" Su Meiqi said: "They're all proper friends. You don't understand young people's world, so don't make baseless criticisms, okay?"

"Yi'an is also a young person. How come she won a Rising Designer award at RT²? How come she found a job? What about you? Apart from messing around all day, what can you do?"

"Uncle." Zhou Yi'an saw the situation turning bad. Under the table, she kicked Su Meiqi, signaling her to say less.

She was about to speak up for Su Meiqi when Su Meiqi jumped up like a mouse whose tail had been stepped on. She kicked Zhou Yi'an back. "If Zhou Yi'an is so great, why don't you recognize her as your daughter? You don't like me anyway."

She pulled her chair aside. "If you like her, make her your daughter. And she's an Alpha too—she's more suitable to inherit your business. See if she's willing to let you be her dad?! I'm the useless one. I'm getting my job offer this week and moving out. I definitely won't stay home and be an eyesore to you!"

Her emotions were too agitated, and her hood fell off.

Her frizzy hair appeared in everyone's view again. She reached up and smoothed it, then turned to go upstairs, but was grabbed by Zhou Yi'an pulling on her pajama tail.

Su Meiqi: "...!!!"

"Let me go." Su Meiqi yelled at her: "Don't pull my tail!"

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

She let go, and saw Su Meiqi march upstairs with great vigor.

Sheng Yu, who had been eating with her head down, looked up in confusion at Su Zhe. "Uncle, you scolded Sister again."

Su Zhe was so angry he nearly had a heart attack. "Your sister is scolding me! Calling me stubborn, autocratic, and inflexible."

Sheng Yu: "...What does that mean?"

Su Zhe also put down his chopsticks and consoled her: "Hurry up and eat. Your sister is a little troublemaker now."

Sheng Yu: "Oh."

Zhou Yi'an said quietly: "Uncle, Qiqi really is looking for work right now, and her credentials aren't low. You could be more lenient with her. Many people nowadays like two-dimensional culture³."

"Don't speak up for her either." Su Zhe said: "She's just a little troublemaker now. Too spoiled."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

She chose to shut up.

In the past when they argued, Su Meiqi would let things go in one ear and out the other. Su Zhe would say a few words and that would be the end of it.

Footnotes:

¹ Comic convention (漫展, mànzhǎn): Short for "manga/anime convention," events where fans of anime, manga, and related media gather. Attendees often dress in cosplay (costume play), which explains Su Meiqi's unusual hairstyle.

² RT: Likely refers to a prestigious design competition or organization mentioned earlier in the story. The acronym stands for a specific design institution that awards emerging designers.

³ Two-dimensional culture (二次元, èr cì yuán): Literally "two-dimensional," this term refers to anime, manga, and related subcultures in Chinese internet slang. It encompasses the world of animation, comics, games, and cosplay—as opposed to "three-dimensional" (三次元) which refers to the real world.

Chapter 71 Part 10

Today Su Meiqi was like a cat with its fur standing on end. She probably wanted to find an excuse to move out of the house.

Zhou Yi'an glanced upstairs, then lowered her head to eat.

Su Yao didn't have much energy. She ate a little at random and then returned to her room to rest. But before going back to her room, she said to Su Zhe: "Don't say those hurtful things to Qiqi. She's already obedient enough. Your temper is too bad. You always put her down."

Su Zhe waved his hand. "Alright, go back to your room and rest. I'll think about it."

"If she doesn't want to enter the company, let Su Nan¹ do it." Su Yao said: "Why is Su Nan's dream a dream, but Qiqi has to give way to him?"

Su Zhe frowned: "If either of these two was willing to enter the company, would I need to do this?"

Su Yao sighed: "Anyway, don't push Qiqi too hard."

Su Zhe said impatiently: "I know."

//

After dinner, Zhou Yi'an held Sheng Yu on the sofa and played with her for a while. Then, thinking of what happened during the day, she directed Sheng Yu to deliver cake to Su Meiqi, who hadn't eaten her fill. She called Su Zhe to the study.

As soon as they entered, Su Zhe spoke: "You don't need to plead for Qiqi. Her temper is getting worse now. She needs to be disciplined, or sooner or later she'll cause real trouble."

"That's not it." When facing elders, Zhou Yi'an's attitude was also very gentle. She said in a low voice: "I'm looking for you to understand something else."

"What is it?" Su Zhe asked.

Zhou Yi'an paused, then still asked: "Do you know that Teacher Su has another daughter?"

Su Zhe frowned. "Isn't it just Sheng Yu?"

"No." Zhou Yi'an said: "The one from the Sheng family, who now has the surname Xu."

Hearing this, Su Zhe's expression immediately changed. He sneered: "I know. What about it?"

Zhou Yi'an said: "Why back then..."

"Keep this matter to yourself." Su Zhe interrupted her. "This child has had the surname Xu for so many years. Are we supposed to have her change it to Sheng now? Speaking of which, Xu Guangyao is black-hearted enough. He didn't even leave the Sheng family's last bit of bloodline—made her take the surname Xu directly. Those two old things fought over her for so long for nothing."

"Fought?" Zhou Yi'an frowned: "So Xu Qingzhu was snatched away by the Sheng family?"

When Su Zhe talked about this matter, his anger rose. He picked up the cold tea on the table and drank it all in one gulp, but was still agitated: "What else? If it weren't for those two old things, would my sister have become like this? Damn it."

Su Zhe was so angry he cursed. "Did my sister kill their son? It was a natural disaster, an act of God. Who could have prevented it? But they came over to scold my sister and snatch the child. Damn it. Su Yao had just finished her postpartum confinement²."

When Su Zhe said this, his anger made his teeth itch and his voice tremble, showing how deep the grudge was.

Zhou Yi'an consoled him at the right time: "Calm down, don't get too worked up."

Su Zhe poured himself another cup of cold tea, trying to cool down the fire in his heart. "I've been holding it in all these years. If it weren't for the fact that my sister's daughter is still there, I would have already brought down Minghui³. What trash."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

Su Zhe let out a light breath. "That girl is quite capable. Have you met her?"

"Mm." Zhou Yi'an said: "We've run into each other a few times. She looks more like Sheng Qinglin, not much like Teacher Su."

So at the time, Zhou Yi'an hadn't connected her with Su Yao.

It was only later when investigating Xu Qingzhu that she traced it back to Su Yao.

...

What enemies they were.

"You become like whoever feeds you." Su Zhe said through gritted teeth: "Last time I saw her, I felt she looked a lot like Sheng Linlang⁴."

Zhou Yi'an smiled. "Don't be angry anymore. It's been so many years."

"Even though it's been so many years, when I think about it, I still want to go to the Sheng family's door and curse them out." Su Zhe sneered: "That shows you how much I hate them. Su Yao had just finished postpartum confinement, and Sheng Qinglin was going to propose to her. He died on the road."

Su Zhe's hands were trembling. "Su Yao was standing right across the street. She watched Sheng Qinglin get hit and killed right in front of her eyes. She was completely dazed."

"They were abroad at the time. The Sheng family rushed over overnight—just those two. When my sister went to their house, they thought she was wonderful in every way. But as soon as their son had an accident, those two changed completely. Su Yao was scared stupid, just crying the whole time. When I got there..."

Su Zhe paused, choking up at the memory. "Su Yao's eyes were so red, like she was going blind. Her daughter was crying in the hospital room too. She was crying. The Sheng family was powerful then. They brought people to snatch the daughter. Su Yao fought with them."

Recalling that scene, Su Zhe couldn't help but redden his eyes.

He watched his own sister, whom he had cherished and loved, kneeling on the ground. Next to her was Sheng Qinglin's body, just covered with a white cloth. She cried and begged the Sheng family couple to return her daughter to her. But those two said this was Sheng Qinglin's only flesh and blood in this world and must return to the Sheng family.

Su Yao cried and said she would have a ghost marriage⁵ with Sheng Qinglin.

That proud person, she bowed down for her daughter, saying she was willing to remain a widow for life, just wanting to keep her only daughter with Sheng Qinglin.

But the Sheng family couple called her unlucky. They said if it weren't for her, their son wouldn't have died.

So they only wanted the daughter, not Su Yao.

Su Zhe had wanted to throw punches at the time, but was no match for the Sheng family's power. He was held back by people.

In the hospital room were the intermingled wails of Su Yao and the child.

The Sheng family snatched away Su Yao's daughter right in front of Sheng Qinglin's corpse, then transported Sheng Qinglin's body back to the country. When they held the funeral, they also barred Su Yao from entering.

Footnotes:

¹ Su Nan (蘇南): Su Meiqi's cousin, mentioned in passing. The name literally means "Su South."

² Postpartum confinement (月子, yuèzi): A traditional Chinese practice where new mothers rest for about 30-40 days after giving birth, following specific dietary and lifestyle restrictions to aid recovery. This period is considered crucial for the mother's health.

³ Minghui (明輝): Refers to Minghui Technology, the Xu family's company that was mentioned earlier in the story.

⁴ Sheng Linlang (盛琳琅): Sheng Qinglin's mother, Xu Qingzhu's paternal grandmother.

⁵ Ghost marriage (冥婚, míng hūn): A traditional Chinese practice where a living person "marries" a deceased person, or two deceased people are married to each other. It's done to fulfill filial obligations or ensure the deceased has companionship in the afterlife. In this context, Su Yao was desperately offering to perform this ritual to stay connected to the Sheng family and keep her daughter.

Chapter 71 Part 11

Su Yao cried day and night, night and day, until she cried one eye blind.

Then every day she would be numb and dazed, thinking about her daughter. Postpartum depression combined with longing turned to illness. Her entire mental state became disordered. She was insane for a long time, until one day when she tried to commit suicide and hit her head on a rock.

She didn't die but lost her memory.

She forgot everyone, only remembering Sheng Qinglin, but only remembering the bits and pieces of their time together.

The memory of Sheng Qinglin's death was too painful, so she forgot it.

The memory of her daughter being snatched away was too painful, so she forgot that too.

Along with it, she forgot Su Zhe, her own brother.

After that came the long road to recovery. Every year her condition would relapse, and she would become crazy and confused.

When Su Zhe thought back to that day, his anger reached the point where he wanted to dig up and whip the corpses of the old Sheng couple.

But he didn't describe the events of that year to Zhou Yi'an in vivid detail. He just explained the whole truth clearly. After finishing, he asked her: "What? Want to help your Teacher Su find her family?"

Zhou Yi'an shook her head: "Teacher Su doesn't even remember. What's the use of finding them?"

"It's not that she doesn't remember." Su Zhe said: "On her daughter's birthday, she becomes especially pained. She cries, she screams, she locks herself in her room and keeps repeating the name Su Qingzhu¹."

"Su Qingzhu?" Zhou Yi'an was surprised.

"That's right." Su Zhe said: "Sheng Qinglin was actually quite good. When Su Yao gave birth to their daughter, he said the daughter was born through Su Yao's hard work, so she should take Su Yao's surname. Then Su Yao put the character 'Qing²' in their daughter's name."

So it should have been Su Qingzhu.

Not Xu Qingzhu.

"Really." Su Zhe said: "If they had even called her Sheng Qingzhu, I could understand. But damn it, they fought so hard to snatch her away, then had her take an outsider's surname. I really want to beat them."

Zhou Yi'an said helplessly: "Then why didn't you snatch her back later?"

"The child was already that old. Wouldn't it be troublesome to have two families fighting over her back and forth?" Su Zhe said: "Besides, Su Yao forgot. It's not good to keep stimulating her. I had people check—Sheng Linlang didn't mistreat the child, so that's fine. Let her grow up peacefully."

Zhou Yi'an had thought Su Zhe would hate the child along with everyone else, but unexpectedly Su Zhe said: "How can I say it—she's still my sister's biological daughter. Although the Sheng family was shameless back then, that child still has to call me uncle. When she kicks Xu Guangyao out, I'll stop suppressing Minghui. Otherwise, I'll keep pressing down on them until they go bankrupt."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

She suddenly understood why Minghui Technology had taken such a sharp downturn in recent years.

Su Zhe was going for revenge.

After hearing this rather heavy story, Zhou Yi'an asked Su Zhe: "If Teacher Su's daughter wanted to come back and acknowledge her family, would you accept it?"

Su Zhe suddenly froze. After a moment, he smiled bitterly: "If Su Yao accepts, I'll accept. She's Su Yao's daughter."

"But it's still better if she doesn't know." Su Zhe said: "If she knew about these sordid matters, she'd feel terrible. People are happiest when they're ignorant."

Zhou Yi'an nodded and promised him: "I'll keep these matters to myself."

Footnotes:

¹ Su Qingzhu (蘇青竹): This reveals that Xu Qingzhu's original name was supposed to be Su Qingzhu, with her mother's surname "Su" (蘇) rather than "Xu" (許). The "Qing" (青) character connects to her father Sheng Qinglin's name (盛清林), showing the family connection.

² Character 'Qing' (青 vs 清): Interestingly, Xu Qingzhu's current name uses 清 (qīng, meaning "clear/pure") while her original intended name would have used 青 (qīng, meaning "blue/green/young"), which is the same character used in her father Sheng Qinglin's name. Both characters are pronounced "qing" but have different meanings and are written differently.

Chapter 71 Part 12

//

When Zhou Yi'an came out of Su Zhe's study, Sheng Yu was standing at the stairway landing, holding an untouched piece of small cake in her hand.

Seeing Zhou Yi'an, she immediately said: "Sister An, my sister won't eat it."

"She won't even eat cake?" Zhou Yi'an said: "I bought it especially for her."

Sheng Yu sighed. "She's lying on the bed crying."

Zhou Yi'an: "?"

"Really or fake?" Zhou Yi'an said: "She cried just from being scolded a few times? That's not like her."

Sheng Yu nodded: "She was crying so sadly."

Zhou Yi'an said helplessly, then rubbed her head. "I'll go check on her."

Sheng Yu followed her upstairs.

Standing at Su Meiqi's door, she knocked. No one answered from inside the room. She opened the door on her own and said: "I'm coming in."

As soon as she entered, a throw pillow came flying at her, landing directly at her feet.

"Get out." Su Meiqi was lying completely prone on the bed, the tail on her pajamas sticking up. She said in a muffled voice: "I never want to see you again."

"Really?" Zhou Yi'an paused. "Fine, then I'll go back and tell Xu Qingzhu that you don't want to come work at the company."

She turned to leave, but before she could get out the door, someone grabbed her clothes.

Those hands pitifully clutched at the hem of her clothes, pulling her back into the room.

Zhou Yi'an glanced and saw that her eyes and nose were crying bright red. The hat with two horns sat loosely on her head, her hair was messy, and her bangs had been pushed to both sides. She looked utterly pitiful.

"Crying like this?" Zhou Yi'an frowned. "Aren't you embarrassed?"

"You don't understand." Su Meiqi sniffled, and tears fell again. She couldn't help sobbing: "You... you're not allowed to go tell Sister Xu... I... I... I want to work."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

She first put the cake on the table. Downstairs, Su Yao was calling for Sheng Yu to wash up.

Zhou Yi'an curled her fingers and tapped Su Meiqi on the head. "Wait a moment."

After saying this, she turned and sent Sheng Yu downstairs, also reminding Su Yao to sleep early.

When she returned, Su Meiqi had gone back to lying on the bed crying.

Zhou Yi'an closed the door, walked to the bedside and pulled her pajama tail. "Are you done crying yet? Get up and eat something when you're done."

"I... I'm not hungry." Su Meiqi cried while answering in a muffled voice: "Don't worry about me. I... I... I feel terrible."

She was crying so hard she couldn't speak properly.

Zhou Yi'an found it quite troublesome. She sat on the edge of the bed and tugged at Su Meiqi's hat, exposing her ridiculously curled hair. "Which comic con did you go to?"

Su Meiqi sniffled: "Jingyu District, a small convention."

"Who were you cosplaying this time?" Zhou Yi'an asked again.

"Crescent Moon Rabbit¹." Su Meiqi said: "You wouldn't know even if I told you."

"Then get up and eat." Zhou Yi'an said: "After you eat, I'm going home."

"Go ahead. I won't eat." Su Meiqi's voice was heavily choked with tears. "I forgive you. You can go."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"When did I ask for your forgiveness?" Zhou Yi'an tapped her on the head. "Hurry up and eat. I bought it especially for you."

Su Meiqi shook her head: "I really can't eat."

As she said this, she got angry again, kicking her legs against the bed and saying in a muffled voice: "Just go. Let me cry for a while."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"Then cry." Zhou Yi'an got up and walked to the window, opening half of it. She took a cigarette from her pocket and lit it.

Su Meiqi got up because of the smoke smell. She wiggled her nose, then lifted her head to see Zhou Yi'an standing by the window smoking, the smoke being blown away by the wind.

Su Meiqi frowned: "You're smoking in my room again. When my dad sees, he'll scold me."

"Just say it was me smoking." Zhou Yi'an said: "My dad knows anyway."

"You didn't get beaten?" Su Meiqi sat up, sniffled, then sneezed. "It's so choking."

Zhou Yi'an turned toward the window, leaving only her back to her.

Su Meiqi got up and tied her messy hair back. "I can't cry with you here."

"Then eat something." Zhou Yi'an said coldly.

"Are you feeling guilty toward me?" Su Meiqi walked to the table and picked up the small cake, taking a bite. "I'm not angry at you. I'm angry at my dad. He could obviously let Su Nan enter the company, but he insists I go in. Yet he doesn't think much of my abilities. I know I'm not as good as you..."

"Can't food shut your mouth?" Zhou Yi'an turned around. The wind blew her shoulder-length hair, which scattered freely in the breeze. Those heartless eyes were shrouded in blue-gray smoke.

Su Meiqi was scared into hiccupping, and a tear fell straight down.

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"You're being mean to me." Su Meiqi felt wronged. "I've already been bullied like this, and you're still being mean to me? You've been mean to me twice today."

Zhou Yi'an: "...Shut up."

Su Meiqi saw she was in a bad mood and stopped talking.

She sat at the table, sobbing while eating that small piece of cake. She left the last bite and walked to the window to give it to Zhou Yi'an.

Zhou Yi'an shook her head: "I won't eat it."

"Eat it." Su Meiqi sniffled. "An exchange."

Zhou Yi'an: "?"

Zhou Yi'an's cigarette was still half remaining, the crimson flame flickering in the dark night. Su Meiqi fed that bite of cake directly into Zhou Yi'an's mouth, then grabbed Zhou Yi'an's wrist, lifted her hand, bent down, and took a drag of the cigarette.

Someone smoking for the first time didn't know the method—didn't even know where the smoke should go. She only knew to inhale and exhale like on TV. As a result, the first drag choked her half to death.

She coughed facing out the window, then took in a big gulp of cold air.

Zhou Yi'an belatedly patted her back. After she gulped down a large mouthful of cold air and coughed even more severely, she turned Su Meiqi's body around to face her instead, letting her cough toward herself.

Su Meiqi braced one hand against the windowsill, coughing as if she would hack up her lungs. She coughed until she crouched down, her face turned red, and many tears fell.

Zhou Yi'an quickly stubbed out the cigarette and waved her hand to disperse the smoke.

¹ Crescent Moon Rabbit (月牙兔, yuèyá tù): A character from anime/manga that Su Meiqi was cosplaying. The elaborate curled hairstyle was part of the costume, explaining why her hair looked so unusual.

Chapter 71 Part 13

After a long while, Su Meiqi finally stopped. She looked up at Zhou Yi'an with an aggrieved expression and said: "Why do you even like this kind of thing?"

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

She stood up. "Kids shouldn't learn these things."

"Sister." Su Meiqi protested. "I'm only four years younger than you."

Zhou Yi'an said: "Then don't learn it either. It's not a good thing."

Su Meiqi huffed lightly but didn't say anything more. She found a carton of milk and a bottle of beverage from her cabinet and tossed the beverage to Zhou Yi'an.

She held the milk and drank it herself.

After a while, Su Meiqi asked: "Have you found that first love of yours yet?"

Zhou Yi'an had just drunk some beverage to soothe her throat. Hearing this, she paused: "Hm?"

"That person you came back to the country to find." Su Meiqi said: "Didn't you return to the country because of her?"

"Found her." Zhou Yi'an said.

Su Meiqi immediately became gossipy. "Where is she? Are you two together?"

"She's married." Zhou Yi'an said calmly.

Su Meiqi: "?"

"No way?" Su Meiqi was shocked: "She didn't even wait for you?"

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"Let's not talk about this." Zhou Yi'an said: "Mind your own business."

Su Meiqi made a dismissive sound. "If I had someone I liked, I'd definitely stick to her. You actually went abroad at that time. How awful. Look, you missed your chance."

Zhou Yi'an chuckled softly. "Then you better stick closely to your girlfriend in the future. Don't come out and harm others."

Su Meiqi lifted her head proudly: "Obviously."

"I don't know which poor soul will have you clinging to them." Zhou Yi'an said: "I'll have a moment of silence for her first."

Su Meiqi threw a pillow at her. "Sister, show some decency!"

Zhou Yi'an curved into a smile but said nothing.

Su Meiqi rolled her eyes at her. "It's because you're too bad that you don't have a girlfriend."

"Do you?" Zhou Yi'an raised an eyebrow.

Su Meiqi: "...Go away!"

//

When Zhou Yi'an left the Su residence, it was already quite late. Sitting in her car smoking, she thought of Su Meiqi and put it down again.

After finding work, she had also moved out of the Zhou house.

Though it was by signing a contract that she got out.

She had to admit, the move Xu Qingzhu pulled on her before was quite effective. Her father made her sign a contract before letting her out. The contract included not causing trouble for the Liang and Xu families.

Mainly because he was afraid she'd cause him trouble.

Right now, sitting in her car, she let her mind go blank. She couldn't help thinking—if she hadn't gone abroad back then, what would things be like now?

Perhaps Liang Shi wouldn't have married Xu Qingzhu?

Zhou Yi'an felt exhausted.

She scrolled through her phone and in the dead of night sent Liang Shi a message: [Did you change only after you fell in love with Xu Qingzhu?]

Footnotes:

None needed for this section.

Chapter 71 Part 14

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Liang Shi saw this message when she woke up in the morning. She figured Zhou Yi'an must have gotten drunk and sent it in a moment of madness, so she deleted the text message.

She had slept quite soundly that night. After getting up, she did a set of exercises, then went to the kitchen to make breakfast, only to find Xu Qingzhu already in the kitchen.

Liang Shi: "?"

She stood at the kitchen doorway and said very seriously: "Teacher Xu, I suspect you're trying to out-compete me."

Xu Qingzhu turned around, her hair casually tied up with a few loose strands falling in front of her chest. Those clear eyes like a little deer's looked over with some confusion, but gave Liang Shi a sense of pressure. "Hm?"

"In the world of internal competition, even waking up early has become a competition." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She turned back to look at the porridge in the pot, saying coolly: "Oh."

Liang Shi walked over and teased: "Teacher Xu, in your short lifetime so far, have you ever lost at anything?"

Xu Qingzhu elbowed her. "Get the bowls."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Stop being so passive-aggressive." Xu Qingzhu said: "I just felt bad always eating the food you make."

Liang Shi shrugged. "What's there to feel bad about? Didn't you wash the dishes?"

"Don't think I don't know." Xu Qingzhu said without changing expression: "After I wash the dishes, you wash them again."

Liang Shi: "..."

She awkwardly touched her nose. "So you saw that."

Xu Qingzhu sneered. "What else?"

Liang Shi said gently: "Teacher Xu, have you considered that someone who can't even wash dishes clean probably can't cook that well either?"

Xu Qingzhu picked up a spoon and raised it, glaring at her. "Teacher Liang, did you sleep too much last night?"

Liang Shi immediately backed away. "No..."

"I think you're unusually lively today." Xu Qingzhu said: "And particularly irritating."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Alright, no more joking." Liang Shi said: "How did you sleep last night?"

"Not bad." Xu Qingzhu said, placing the bowl of porridge on the table. It was a bit hot, so she pinched her earlobe. "Eat. After eating, we'll go to work."

Liang Shi stared at her busy figure, guessing in her heart that she probably wanted to use this method to keep herself from overthinking.

So during the meal, Liang Shi diverted her attention: "I'll come pick you up after work today."

Xu Qingzhu: "Why?"

Liang Shi said: "To declare my sovereignty."

Xu Qingzhu was puzzled: "No one's pursuing me. What are you declaring?"

Liang Shi said: "For you to declare."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

"Zhou Yi'an sent me a text message last night." Liang Shi said: "It was really strange. I think we need to appear together as a united front. What do you think?"

This phrasing was very much like speaking to a business partner—very official.

Xu Qingzhu agreed. "Fine."

Liang Shi also mentioned that she had arranged to meet with a real estate agent to look at apartments today, and they could go together in the evening.

Xu Qingzhu agreed to everything.

Footnotes:

None needed for this section.

Chapter 71 Part 15

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After Xu Qingzhu arrived at work, she didn't see Zhou Yi'an. Upon asking the department head, she learned that Zhou Yi'an had requested half a day off.

She even exchanged messages with Liang Shi: [Zhou Yi'an didn't come to work.]

Liang Shi: [She probably got drunk somewhere.]

Xu Qingzhu didn't pay it any more mind.

In the afternoon, Zhou Yi'an came in, no different from her usual state.

HR also sent onboarding emails to the new colleagues who had passed the interviews. After sending them, they reported the progress to Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu asked one extra question: "Did you send Su Meiqi's?"

HR said: "Sent."

Because of this question, Xu Qingzhu was distracted all afternoon until after work.

Liang Shi sent her a message: [Come downstairs.]

Only then did she pack up her things and leave the office. At the elevator entrance, she ran into Zhou Yi'an again.

Zhou Yi'an saw her and frowned in surprise: "Aren't you working overtime?"

Xu Qingzhu said: "I have something today."

Zhou Yi'an didn't respond to this, just lowered her head to tap at her phone, seemingly sending someone a message.

Xu Qingzhu rode the elevator down with her. There was no signal in the elevator.

As soon as the elevator doors opened, Zhou Yi'an rushed out like a gust of wind. This was the first time Xu Qingzhu had seen her behave in such a flustered manner. She stood there stunned for a moment, then walked outside.

Liang Shi, who was waiting downstairs, had already spotted Su Yao and Sheng Yu.

One adult and one child stood there, along with Su Meiqi dressed in flashy clothes.

Su Meiqi was crouched down playing with Sheng Yu, while Su Yao stood there in a daze.

Her figure was excellent. She stood there straight as a tree, looking up at this building.

After playing with Sheng Yu, Su Meiqi also stood up and said something to her.

Su Yao suddenly curved her lips into a smile. When she smiled unconsciously, the arc was very similar to Xu Qingzhu's.

Liang Shi lowered her head and sent Xu Qingzhu a message: [I have something to take care of right now. I'm leaving first. I'll come back to pick you up in a bit.]

Although she didn't know what these three people were doing here, Liang Shi felt it would be better not to let Xu Qingzhu see them.

But she hadn't expected that just as she sent the message, Zhou Yi'an would run out.

And Xu Qingzhu followed right behind her.

It was almost the moment Zhou Yi'an ran up to Su Yao that Xu Qingzhu also walked out of the office building.

After making eye contact with Liang Shi, she immediately looked in Zhou Yi'an's direction.

Liang Shi: "..."

She quickly called out: "Xu Qingzhu, come here."

But Xu Qingzhu stood there without moving, her gaze fixed intently in that direction.

The group of three adults and one child over there were talking. Then Zhou Yi'an turned to glance at Xu Qingzhu. Her tall figure almost completely blocked Su Yao, as if she was also afraid of being seen.

Xu Qingzhu curved her lips into a smile, extremely radiant.

Liang Shi walked over quickly, afraid her emotions would become unstable like at the cemetery. She grasped her hand and coaxed in a low voice: "Let's go."

The people over there were already getting into their car.

But Xu Qingzhu took a heavy breath, then gripped Liang Shi's hand in return. She turned to look at Liang Shi. The setting sun fell on her face, making her appear much gentler overall. "Teacher Liang, no matter what I do, you'll support me, right?"

In that instant, Liang Shi understood what she wanted to do.

But she only nodded. "What I've said will always count."

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes, then turned and shouted loudly: "Zhou Yi'an, Su Meiqi."

Zhou Yi'an's back stiffened. Su Meiqi's eyes lit up as she jumped and shouted: "Sister Xu!"

Xu Qingzhu pulled Liang Shi along, step by step toward Su Yao's direction, walking firmly forward.

None needed for this section.